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Public Policy Analysis

Fifth Edition

WILLIAM N. DUNN

Graduate School of Public and International Affairs
University of Pittsburgh

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In memory of Donald T. Campbell

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PREFACE

My aim in writing the several editions of this book has been to produce a critical synthesis of the field, while at the same time offering students, instructors, and practitioners a body of knowledge and skills that is applicable to real-world problems. This is not a text in the narrow and conventional sense of the term.

Ever since the publication of the first edition of *Public Policy Analysis* more than thirty years ago, I have become more and more convinced that the methodology of policy analysis rests or should rest on epistemological foundations that differ from those of the disciplines of which policy analysis is composed. For this reason, I continue to define policy analysis as an applied social science discipline that employs multiple methods of inquiry to solve practical problems.

What this means is that the methodology of policy analysis cannot be reduced to the theories and analytical routines of microeconomics, because solutions for practical problems demand much more than the analysis of rational choice, expected utility, and opportunity costs. By the same token, the methodology of policy analysis cannot be reduced to the study of politics, because solutions for practical problems require more than the analysis of power, rule, and authority or who gets what, when, and how. Much more is involved. Finally, because a principal aim of policy analysis is to improve policies, the methodology of policy analysis cannot be reduced to an academic spectator sport in which knowledge is prized for its own sake.

This broadly accessible 5th edition employs a simplified style of writing, cases based on real-world analytical practices, and visual displays that make complex ideas understandable. Examples and case materials now include issues in foreign policy and international security as well as domestic issues including environmental justice, urban economics, transportation, and public safety. ~~Advanced~~ graphics software for mapping and evaluating policy arguments cultivate~~s~~ critical thinking skills in areas ranging from qualitative forecasting and statistical analysis to theories of justice. The book also provides student with practical and marketable skills in communicating policy analysis ~~through~~ policy memos, position papers, and other forms of structured analytical writing. Finally, new study suggestions and demonstration exercises emphasize active rather than passive learning.

Special instructional devices and learning strategies are again employed throughout the book:

- *Advance organizers.* The book uses advance organizers, especially visual displays, to introduce students to the logic and organization of methods. The advance organizer for the book as a whole is the information-processing model of policy analysis presented in the first chapter.
- *Learning objectives.* At the beginning of each chapter is an explicit statement of the learning objectives that students should be able to attain

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by reading the chapter and completing its study questions and demonstration exercises. I have tried to state these objectives in terms of the acquisition of knowledge and skills to do or perform something—that is, behaviorally defined learning objectives that involve recognizing, defining, understanding, explaining, predicting, evaluating, and applying. By stating objectives in this way, the emphasis is on active rather than passive learning, on application rather than regurgitation.

- *Review questions.* Knowledge and skills must be reinforced. For this reason, review questions are provided at the end of each chapter. The review questions address *higher-order* knowledge and skills (e.g., explaining or applying) as well as *lower-order* knowledge and skills (e.g., calculating or estimating). Review questions may be used by students for self-study and by instructors who are developing written assignments, examinations, and tests.
- *Demonstration exercises.* Knowledge and skills are not acquired or retained without frequent opportunities for application to real-world problems. For this reason, each chapter contains opportunities to demonstrate the application of knowledge and skills to significant practical problems. The attempt is to draw students away from "blackboard policy analysis" into the real world of messy problems and provisional solutions.
- *Cases.* Cases in policy analysis are the focus of the demonstration exercises. Cases span a number of issue areas including foreign policy and security, transportation policy, occupational health and safety, and urban policy. Some cases are primarily conceptual; most are methodological in nature.
- *Bibliographies.* In addition to literature cited in footnotes, each chapter is accompanied by a list of readings that are keyed to the subject matter of that chapter. I have attempted to include literature that is representative of many of the most important developments in public policy analysis.
- *Guidelines for written and oral communication.* Students who master methods almost always face difficulties when they must communicate the results of analysis through policy memoranda, position papers, issue papers, and oral briefings. To help overcome these difficulties, appendices present step-by-step guidelines and checklists.
- *Argument maps.* Analysis is about making and understanding policy arguments. This edition uses numerous argument maps created with *Rationale,* an exceptionally useful and innovative computer program available at www.austhink.com. Elsewhere I have expressed my gratitude to Professor Tim van Gelder, one of the originators of the program, for his help.

SUPPLEMENTS

WEBSITE A special website (www.policyonline.org) supports users of this book by providing slides keyed to each chapter and data sets related to cases covered in the chapters. Many of the slides can serve as teaching notes.

ARGUMENT MAPPING SOFTWARE Users of this book may purchase ~~Rationale 2~~ at a student discount by visiting www.austhinkconsulting.com/dunn.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I would not have begun this ambitious multidisciplinary project without the encouragement of the late Paul F. Lazarsfeld, who challenged me to investigate and write about what he called the "policy sciences movement." Lazarsfeld, one of a handful of premier applied social scientists of the twentieth century, was skeptical of the enterprise, as it had been sketched by Lasswell, Kaplan, Lerner, and others. Its aims seemed to him unwisely all-encompassing and grand, an assessment that holds some truth today. Lazarsfeld did not self-identify as a sociologist, but as an applied social scientist and, for this reason, he was University Professor of Social Science at the University of Pittsburgh.

Some ten years later, we made an ultimately unsuccessful attempt to fill Lazarsfeld's vacant chair with another premier applied social scientist, Donald T. Campbell, who virtually revolutionized the methodology of the applied social sciences in the twentieth century. Campbell, like Lazarsfeld, did not self-identify with his original discipline, which was social psychology. Instead, he viewed himself as a multidisciplinary applied social scientist specializing in program and policy evaluation and the philosophy and sociology of science. Campbell's mentorship has had a profound effect on the way I think about the strengths and limitations of policy analysis and program evaluation. His imprint can be seen throughout this book.

At about the same time, I was asked to join a team of faculty who were developing curricular materials on policy analysis for practitioners in local governments. The group had wisely contracted specialists in learning theory and curriculum development, including Doris Gow and Jyotsna Vasudev. I learned from them the important pedagogical lesson that abstract subjects such as policy analysis can be more effectively taught by focusing on behaviorally defined learning objectives. I am grateful to them for making me see that much of the literature we assign in courses is not easily or successfully tied to learning outcomes, which means that we often cannot say why we want students to read the materials we assign. This was a revelation.

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In the past thirty years and more, this book has been used in degree and certificate programs in universities, think tanks, and governments in this country and abroad. Translations into Arabic, Chinese, Indonesian, Korean, Macedonian, Romanian, and Spanish are completed or under way. The book has been used in training programs and projects in countries of the European Union, Southeastern Europe, the Middle East, North Africa, and Latin America. The revisions incorporated in this edition reflect much of what I have learned from the participants and organizers of these programs.

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William N. Dunn
Graduate School of Public and International Affairs
University of Pittsburgh